THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY

BOOK ONE: BEFORE

Chapter 10 — "Election Day"

Tuesday, November 5, 2024 – Wednesday, November 6, 2024

COLD OPEN — "SEVENTY-EIGHT YEARS"

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — ODESSA'S BEDROOM — CASCADE HEIGHTS, ATLANTA — PRE-DAWN

SUPER: TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 5, 2024 — 5:31 AM EST

SUPER: ELECTION DAY

A bedroom that hasn't changed since 1979. A four-poster bed. A vanity covered in perfume bottles from department stores that no longer exist. Photographs on every surface: a wedding in 1946, a baby in 1947, a march across a bridge, a funeral in 1974, another in 2009.

ODESSA SMILLEY (96) sits on the edge of her bed in the dark, fully dressed. She's been dressed since 4:45. A navy suit. Pearls. A white church hat. Her pocketbook in her lap. Her voter registration card in the pocketbook, laminated by her son in 1988 because she wouldn't stop carrying the original.

A soft knock. The door opens. CORNELIUS SMILLEY (66), in a suit and his father's burgundy tie.

CORNELIUS
Mother. The polls don't open for an hour and a half.

ODESSA
I know when the polls open, Cornelius. I've known when the polls open for seventy-eight years.

CORNELIUS
You'll be first in line again.

ODESSA
I'm always first in line. You know why?

CORNELIUS
...Because in 1946 they made you wait at the back.

She looks up at him. Surprised he remembers.

ODESSA
November of 1946. I was eighteen years old. Georgia was the first state in the country to let eighteen-year-olds vote, and the courts had just thrown out the white primary. Your daddy and I walked to the polling place on Auburn Avenue at six in the morning, and a man at the door made every colored person stand at the back of the line. We stood there until two in the afternoon. A woman in front of me fainted. And when I finally got in that booth, I was shaking so hard I could barely hold the pencil.

(beat)
Seventy-eight years. Every election. I've never once stood at the back again.

Cornelius kneels in front of his mother. Takes her hands.

CORNELIUS
You know who you're voting for this morning?

ODESSA
I've known since that boy said "Bet" on my television.

(beat, a sly look)
Do you?

A long pause.

CORNELIUS
I voted early, Mother. Last Thursday. At the library on Cascade.

ODESSA
You didn't tell me.

CORNELIUS
You didn't ask.

ODESSA
I'm asking now.

Cornelius looks at his mother. Then at the photographs on the vanity. Thaddeus, twenty-two, laughing. Josiah, in his pulpit.

CORNELIUS
I voted for my son-in-law.

Odessa squeezes his hands. Says nothing. She doesn't have to.

CORNELIUS
And then I went home and sat in the car for eleven minutes.

ODESSA
That's a Smilley for you.

CUT TO:

EXT. CASCADE UNITED METHODIST CHURCH — POLLING PLACE — ATLANTA — DAWN

SUPER: 6:58 AM EST

A line of three hundred people stretching around the block in the November chill. At the very front, at the door, in a wheelchair, in her white church hat: Odessa. Behind her, holding the handles: Cornelius. Behind him: Lorraine (62), Neil (40), and Simone (37).

A POLL WORKER (70s), a Black woman who has worked this precinct since 1988, opens the door at exactly 7:00 and looks down.

POLL WORKER
Mother Smilley. First in line again.

ODESSA
Always, Bernice.

As Cornelius wheels her through the door, the people in line start to applaud. Then they don't stop. Three hundred people on a cold Atlanta sidewalk applauding a ninety-six-year-old woman going in to vote.

Simone, behind her father, is crying. She's about to vote for a Democrat for the first time in her life.

SIMONE
(whispering to Neil)
I'm going to throw up.

NEIL
You're going to be fine.

SIMONE
I worked for Nikki Haley, Neil.

NEIL
And now you're voting for character. You said it on CNN. Big Mama has it on DVR.

Twitter · @ATLvotes

Odessa Smilley, 96, first in line at her Cascade precinct at 7:00 AM sharp, as she has been, family members say, at every election since 1946. 300 people applauded.

92K Retweets · 701K Likes · 7:14 AM EST

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

First time voting for a Democrat. My hand shook. My grandmother said, "Mine shook in 1946, baby. That's how you know it matters."

201K Retweets · 1.8M Likes · 7:31 AM EST

ACT ONE — "THE LONGEST DAY"

MONTAGE — AMERICA VOTES — NOVEMBER 5, 2024

— 6:00 AM EST. Dixville Notch, New Hampshire. A handful of residents in a hotel ballroom cast the first votes of Election Day at midnight, as they have since 1960. Result: Bullock 4, Trump 2. The internet declares it a landslide.

— 7:00 AM EST. Philadelphia. A line around a rowhouse block in North Philly. A Puerto Rican grandmother in a "NO SOMOS BASURA" t-shirt, holding her grandson's hand.

— 7:00 AM CST. Houston, Meyerland. The library. Roy Chapman (67) and MAE CHAPMAN (65). Poll worker Darlene again. She slides two forms across the table.

DARLENE
You know you're on the TV every twelve minutes, Roy.

ROY
I'm aware, Darlene.

DARLENE
My husband voted for your boy last week. Because of you. He's never voted for a Democrat in his life. He said, "If Roy can do it."

Roy looks at her for a long moment. Takes his ballot.

ROY
Tell your husband don't make it a whole thing.

DARLENE
Roy, you made it a whole thing. You made it the WHOLE thing.

— 8:15 AM PST. View Park, Los Angeles. Amond Baker (32) and Harmony (32) walk Gloria Baker (58) to the vote center at a community recreation center. Lyric (10), in a "BET." hat, holds her grandmother's other hand. At the check-in table, the poll worker looks at Amond's ID, then up at him.

POLL WORKER (VIEW PARK)
You're voting for yourself?

AMOND
I'm voting for my best friend. I'm on the same line, it's a coincidence.

— 9:02 AM PST. Bel Air. The same church vote center on Sunset as in March. Marc (32) and Esther (32), Emma and Victoria (12), and five Secret Service agents. And at the "I VOTED" sticker table, of course: MRS. EDNA (77), thirty-eight years of kindergarten, who has worked this vote center for nine years and has requested this precinct specifically.

MRS. EDNA
Well. My favorite and my biggest problem. One last time.

MARC
Mrs. Edna, if I win, I'm inviting you to the White House.

MRS. EDNA
If you win, young man, I'm inviting myself.

She puts the sticker on his chest. Then on Esther's. Then she reaches into her apron pocket and pulls out two more, special ones, gold-foil stars that say "FUTURE VOTER," and presses them onto Emma's and Victoria's sweaters.

MRS. EDNA
Twenty thirty. That's your first one. Don't you dare miss it.

EMMA
We turn eighteen May tenth, twenty thirty. The midterms are November fifth. We'll be first in line.

VICTORIA
She has a spreadsheet for it.

EMMA
It's a calendar.

VICTORIA
It's a spreadsheet shaped like a calendar.

— 10:30 AM EST. Washington, D.C. The White House. President Joe Biden (81), who voted early in Delaware, sits in the Oval Office reviewing the President's Daily Brief. On a side table, muted, ABC News. He glances at it. Smiles. Goes back to work.

— 11:47 AM EST. An undisclosed soundstage. Location withheld. A figure in half a suit of violet-and-green armor sits in a chair marked "C.R." holding an absentee-ballot receipt confirmation on his phone. "Your ballot has been accepted — Los Angeles County." He types a text.

TYRESE — to MARC — [TIME WITHHELD]

Voted. From the multiverse. Can't be there tonight. You know why. Go be President. Then I'll go be terrifying.

MARC — 8:49 AM PST

Love you, Conqueror.

— 12:00 PM CST. Swannanoa, North Carolina. A temporary polling place in a FEMA tent next to a church destroyed by Helene. A line of mountain people in muddy boots who walked two miles because the road is gone. An ELDERLY WOMAN in a raincoat over a nightgown. The same woman from September. She votes. On her way out, a local reporter asks who she voted for.

ELDERLY WOMAN
I said in September I was voting for the other fella.

(beat)
Then that boy's daddy-in-law brought me two cases of water and I changed my mind. Don't tell my husband.

Twitter · @AP

Voters across the country head to the polls in what officials expect to be one of the highest-turnout elections in modern history, with more than 80 million Americans having already voted early.

41K Retweets · 188K Likes

TikTok · @mrsedna.kindergarten

[Video posted by her grandson: Mrs. Edna, 77, putting an "I VOTED" sticker on Marc-Anthony Bullock, then "FUTURE VOTER" stars on his twins] "my grandma taught kindergarten for 38 years and she just told a presidential candidate he's her 'biggest problem' to his face"

19.4M views · 5.1M likes

INT. BULLOCK FOR AMERICA HQ — CENTURY CITY — WAR ROOM — AFTERNOON

SUPER: 2:14 PM PST / 5:14 PM EST

Patti Grove (60) at the head of the war room, in a fresh suit, which means she went home at 4 AM to change. She stands in front of the wall map. Elxa (34), Grace (30), Arianna (32). A dozen data staffers at laptops.

PATTI
Exit polls start coming in at five Eastern. They're garbage. I want to say that up front. Exit polls are garbage. They were garbage in 2004, they were garbage in 2016, they'll be garbage tonight. Nobody reacts to an exit poll. Nobody tweets about an exit poll. Grace.

GRACE
Why are you looking at me?

PATTI
Because you're going to tweet about an exit poll.

GRACE
I am NOT —

PATTI
Give me the phone.

Grace hands over her phone. Patti puts it in a desk drawer and locks it.

ELXA
Turnout?

PATTI
Insane. Lines in Philadelphia, Detroit, Milwaukee, Atlanta, Charlotte, Phoenix. Young turnout looks like 2008. Latino turnout in Pennsylvania looks like nothing I've ever seen. Puerto Rican precincts in Allentown and Reading are at eighty percent of registered by two PM.

ARIANNA
And the other side?

PATTI
Rural turnout is huge too. Huge. Trump voters are showing up exactly the way Diane Kastle said they would. Don't let the city lines fool you. This is going to be closer than the polls for the first four hours. It always is. The rural counties count first. We're going to be behind in Pennsylvania at nine o'clock. We're going to be behind in Georgia at ten. We might be behind in Wisconsin at midnight. Do NOT panic until two.

ELXA
And at two?

PATTI
At two, I panic, and you're all invited.

Arianna's laptop pings. She looks at it.

ARIANNA
Kentucky. The governor's office. A statement for tonight, embargoed until polls close. If Marc wins, he'll call a special session of the legislature to take up the 28th Amendment before Christmas.

The room cheers.

PATTI
That's one. Thirty-four.

ARIANNA
If they pass it.

PATTI
They'll pass it. If we win, they'll pass it. Everybody loves a winner. Especially state legislators.

INT. TRUMP CAMPAIGN — WAR ROOM — WEST PALM BEACH — AFTERNOON

SUPER: 5:32 PM EST

The fictionalized Trump war room. Wes Thornton (45), sleeves rolled up, red tie loosened, staring at early exit-poll data on a laptop. Around him, younger strategists, tense.

YOUNGER STRATEGIST
Exits have us down six nationally. Down four in Pennsylvania. Down seven in Michigan.

WES THORNTON
Exits are garbage.

YOUNGER STRATEGIST
They had us right in 2016.

WES THORNTON
They had us WRONG in 2016. That's why we won.

He scrolls. Stops. A number on the screen: "TX EXIT — BULLOCK 49.6 / TRUMP 49.1."

He stares at it.

WES THORNTON
...That's garbage too.

YOUNGER STRATEGIST
Is it?

Wes doesn't answer. He picks up his phone. Scrolls to a contact he blocked from the other side in April: "CORNELIUS SMILLEY." He can't call him. He knows he can't. He looks at the name anyway. Then he puts the phone face-down.

ACT TWO — "THE CALLS"

INT. ABC NEWS — ELECTION HEADQUARTERS — TIMES SQUARE — NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 5, 2024 — 6:58 PM EST / 3:58 PM PST

ABC's election-night set at full power. The giant map. The Decision Desk behind glass. Countdown clocks for every state. Times Square outside the windows, packed with people watching the giant screens.

DAVID MUIR (50) and GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (63) at the center desk. The ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR at the map. DR. MALCOLM REESE (55) and REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE (61) at an analysts' table.

DAVID MUIR
Good evening, and welcome to our coverage of Election Night 2024. Tonight, the American people choose between Donald Trump, the forty-fifth President, seeking to become the forty-seventh, and Marc-Anthony Bullock, thirty-two years old, seeking to become the youngest President in American history, if the Constitution allows him to serve.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And we should say up front: even after tonight, there may be a second count. Thirty-three states have ratified the 28th Amendment. Thirty-eight are needed by January twentieth. If the Bullock-Baker ticket wins tonight, the battle moves to state legislatures. And if it falls short there, the race for the House of Representatives becomes the race for the presidency.

DAVID MUIR
ABC News and 538 are owned by Donohue Entertainment, in which Mr. Bullock has a stake held in a blind trust. Polls are closing in Georgia, Virginia, Vermont, Indiana, Kentucky, and South Carolina in less than two minutes.

CHYRON: ELECTION NIGHT 2024 — 270 TO WIN — FIRST POLLS CLOSE 7 PM EST

INT. LOS ANGELES MEMORIAL COLISEUM — FAMILY HOLDING ROOM — LOS ANGELES — SAME TIME

SUPER: 3:59 PM PST

Beneath the peristyle of the Coliseum: a large room that, during USC home games, is a donor lounge. Tonight it's a family room. Couches. Televisions on every wall. A buffet nobody has touched. Out the window, the stadium bowl filling with people: seventy-seven thousand expected, the gates open since 2 PM.

On a long velvet couch in front of the biggest TV: Marc (32) in a navy suit, jacket off, tie loose. Esther (32) beside him. Emma and Victoria (12) on the floor with Emma's laptop. The spreadsheet tab now reads: "DADDY ELECTORAL VOTES (DO NOT TOUCH, VICTORIA, I MEAN IT THIS TIME)."

Around the room: Natasha (53), Robert (55), Victor (78), and Joan (76). Amond (32), Harmony (32), Lyric (10), Gloria Baker (58). Tayia (32) and Tyler (32). And, flown in from Atlanta on a morning flight, in a corner armchair with a blanket over her knees: Odessa (96). Beside her, standing, never sitting: Cornelius (66). Lorraine (62), Neil (40), and Simone (37) at a side table.

Every person who has mattered for nineteen months, in one room.

VICTORIA
When do we find out?

EMMA
It depends. If it's a landslide, maybe by eight our time. If it's close, maybe days. In 2020 it took four days.

VICTORIA
FOUR DAYS? I have a math test Thursday.

MARC
Vic, if we win, you're not taking a math test Thursday.

ESTHER
She's absolutely taking the math test Thursday.

VICTORIA
What if Daddy's President?

ESTHER
Then the President's daughter takes her math test.

Victoria flops back onto the carpet in despair. Lyric giggles.

INT. ABC NEWS — ELECTION HEADQUARTERS — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 7:00:00 PM EST

The chime. The whoosh.

DAVID MUIR
It is seven o'clock on the East Coast. And ABC News can now make our first projections of the night. Donald Trump wins Indiana and Kentucky. Marc-Anthony Bullock wins Vermont. In Virginia, too early to call. And in Georgia...

A beat.

DAVID MUIR
...too close to call.

CHYRON: GEORGIA: TOO CLOSE TO CALL

GRAPHIC — "ELECTORAL VOTES: TRUMP 19 · BULLOCK 3"

MONTAGE — THE EARLY HOURS — 7:00 PM TO 10:30 PM EST

SUPER: 7:30 PM EST

DAVID MUIR (V.O.)
Polls have closed in North Carolina, Ohio, and West Virginia. Trump wins West Virginia. North Carolina: too close to call. Ohio: too early to call.

SUPER: 8:00 PM EST

DAVID MUIR (V.O.)
A big wave of projections. Bullock wins Massachusetts, Maryland, New Jersey, Illinois, Connecticut, Delaware, Rhode Island, the District of Columbia, New Hampshire, and Maine statewide. Trump wins Alabama, Mississippi, Tennessee, Oklahoma, Missouri, and South Carolina. Pennsylvania and Michigan: too early to call. And Florida: too early to call.

GRAPHIC — "ELECTORAL VOTES: BULLOCK 81 · TRUMP 75"

SUPER: 8:29 PM EST

DAVID MUIR (V.O.)
ABC News projects Bullock wins Virginia. And Trump wins Arkansas.

SUPER: 8:52 PM EST

DAVID MUIR (V.O.)
ABC News projects Donald Trump wins Florida, and its thirty electoral votes.

A small cheer from the Trump war room. Wes Thornton doesn't cheer.

SUPER: 9:00 PM EST

DAVID MUIR (V.O.)
Nine o'clock. Bullock wins New York, Minnesota, Colorado, and New Mexico. Trump wins Louisiana, Kansas, Nebraska statewide, Wyoming, and the Dakotas. Wisconsin and Arizona: too early to call. And Texas...

The map. Texas, glowing gray, in the middle of the country.

DAVID MUIR (V.O.)
...too close to call.

GRAPHIC — "ELECTORAL VOTES: BULLOCK 147 · TRUMP 138"

INT. CHAPMAN HOUSE — MEYERLAND, HOUSTON — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 8:01 PM CST

Roy (67) in the recliner. Mae (65) on the couch. On the TV: "TEXAS: TOO CLOSE TO CALL." Roy sets down his reading glasses.

ROY
Too close to call.

MAE
Too close to call, Roy.

ROY
In Texas.

MAE
In Texas.

He stares at the screen. Then gets up, goes to the kitchen, opens the refrigerator, and stands in front of it for a full minute without taking anything out.

MAE
Roy, what are you doing?

ROY
(from the kitchen)
I'm having a whole thing, Mae.

Mae starts laughing so hard she has to put her coffee down.

SUPER: 9:41 PM EST

DAVID MUIR (V.O.)
ABC News projects Donald Trump wins Ohio.

GRAPHIC — "ELECTORAL VOTES: BULLOCK 147 · TRUMP 155"

INT. COLISEUM — FAMILY HOLDING ROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 6:41 PM PST

The room has gotten quieter. Ohio just went Trump. Florida went Trump. Georgia, Pennsylvania, Michigan, Wisconsin, North Carolina, Arizona, Nevada, and Texas are all still gray. The electoral count is nearly even.

Marc is on his feet, pacing behind the couch. Esther watches him. Patti, on speakerphone from the war room upstairs, is a calm voice coming out of Elxa's phone.

PATTI (V.O.)
This is exactly what I said would happen. Rural counties first. Florida was always going to go. Ohio was always going to go. Look at Pennsylvania. Philly's barely counted. Allegheny's barely counted. We're down six statewide with sixty percent in, and the sixty percent is the wrong sixty percent. We're fine.

MARC
We're down six in Pennsylvania.

PATTI (V.O.)
With Philadelphia sitting in a warehouse uncounted. Breathe, Marc.

Marc stops pacing. Turns. Looks across the room at Cornelius, standing beside his mother's armchair, perfectly still.

MARC
Dad. Georgia?

Cornelius doesn't look at the TV. He looks at his phone. A text thread with someone labeled "BERNICE — CASCADE PRECINCT."

CORNELIUS
Fulton isn't in. DeKalb isn't in. Clayton isn't in. The Cascade precinct ran out of "I Voted" stickers at three o'clock. Bernice says she's never seen anything like it. Not in 2008.

(beat)
We're going to win Georgia, son.

It's the first time he's ever said "we."

Odessa, in the armchair, pats his hand.

BACK TO: ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS

SUPER: 10:00 PM EST

DAVID MUIR
Ten o'clock. Trump wins Montana, Utah, and Iowa. Nevada: too early to call. And in the Senate, a significant early result: ABC News projects Republican Jim Justice wins West Virginia, flipping the seat held by retiring Senator Joe Manchin. Democrats can afford to lose only one.

SUPER: 10:41 PM EST

The chime. A bigger whoosh.

DAVID MUIR
A major projection. ABC News projects Marc-Anthony Bullock wins Georgia.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS PROJECTS: BULLOCK WINS GEORGIA — 16 ELECTORAL VOTES

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
A state Trump won in 2016, lost narrowly in 2020, and fought hard for this year. Bullock ran up enormous margins in Fulton, DeKalb, Clayton, and Gwinnett, and our exit polls show he won Black voters in Georgia by a margin larger than Obama's in 2008. His wife is from Atlanta. His father-in-law is a former Georgia congressman who, eight months ago, ran the President's campaign against him there.

GRAPHIC — "ELECTORAL VOTES: BULLOCK 163 · TRUMP 171"

INT. COLISEUM — FAMILY HOLDING ROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 7:41 PM PST

The room EXPLODES. Victoria screams. Lyric screams. Neil throws his arms around Simone. Lorraine covers her face.

Esther turns to her father. Cornelius hasn't moved. He's looking at the TV. At "BULLOCK WINS GEORGIA." At the map, his state now

Bullock teal.

Odessa, in the armchair, takes her son's hand in both of hers.

ODESSA
Seventy-eight years, Cornelius.

CORNELIUS
(barely audible)
I know, Mother.

ODESSA
Your daddy would be standing on that couch right now.

Cornelius closes his eyes. When he opens them, they're wet.

Esther crosses the room. Stands in front of her father. He looks at her. For a moment, neither of them says anything. Then he opens his arms, and she walks into them, and he holds his daughter the way he hasn't since she was nineteen.

CORNELIUS
(into her hair)
I'm sorry, baby. For all of it.

ESTHER
I know, Daddy.

CORNELIUS
I'm so proud of you. You won Georgia. Not him. You. In that church.

ESTHER
We won Georgia, Daddy. All of us.

Across the room, Marc is watching. Amond puts a hand on his shoulder.

> **Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily**
>
> GEORGIA. GEORGIA. GEORGIA. ODESSA SMILLEY VOTED FIRST AT 7AM AND GEORGIA WENT BLUE. THE FIREWALL BUILT FOR BIDEN WAS REBUILT FOR US.
>
> **401K Retweets · 2.9M Likes · 10:43 PM EST**

> **Twitter · @SimoneSmilley**
>
> My first vote for a Democrat and Georgia went blue. I'm not saying it was me. I'm saying it wasn't NOT me.
>
> **211K Retweets · 1.6M Likes**

ACT THREE — "THE BLUE WALL"

INT. ABC NEWS — ELECTION HEADQUARTERS — NIGHT

SUPER: 11:00 PM EST / 8:00 PM PST

DAVID MUIR
Eleven o'clock. Polls have closed on the West Coast. ABC News projects Bullock wins California, Washington, Oregon, and Hawaii, and Nebraska's Second District. Trump wins Idaho.

GRAPHIC — "ELECTORAL VOTES: BULLOCK 242 · TRUMP 175"

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Two hundred and forty-two. Twenty-eight short of the presidency. And now everything comes down to the battlegrounds still out: Michigan, Wisconsin, Pennsylvania, North Carolina, Arizona, Nevada, and Texas.

DAVID MUIR
Dr. Reese, where's Bullock's path?

DR. MALCOLM REESE
The blue wall, David. Michigan, Wisconsin, Pennsylvania. He wins those three, he's President-elect, even without anything else. Right now he's leading in Michigan. Wisconsin is tight. And Pennsylvania has been flipping toward him for the last two hours, as Philadelphia and its suburbs come in.

DAVID MUIR
Congresswoman Kastle, does Trump have a path?

REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE
He needs ninety-five. He's got North Carolina, maybe. Arizona, maybe. Texas, probably, I'd think, though I've stopped being sure of anything tonight. But to win, he has to sweep the blue wall. All three. And honestly, David, looking at these numbers in Philadelphia and Detroit, I don't see it.

INT. SENATE RACES — MONTAGE — 11:12 PM TO 12:30 AM EST

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (V.O.)
Meanwhile, the Senate. ABC News projects Democrat Sherrod Brown holds Ohio, even as Trump carries the state. One of the great survivors in American politics.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (V.O.)
In Montana, a stunner: Senator Jon Tester narrowly holds his seat. In Michigan, Elissa Slotkin wins the open seat. In Pennsylvania, Senator Bob Casey holds on.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (V.O.)
And in Florida, the Senate race between Senator Rick Scott and Democrat Debbie Mucarsel-Powell is too close to call, and may be headed to an automatic recount.

BACK TO: ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS

SUPER: 11:48 PM EST

The chime.

DAVID MUIR
ABC News projects Marc-Anthony Bullock wins Michigan.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS PROJECTS: BULLOCK WINS MICHIGAN — 15 ELECTORAL VOTES

GRAPHIC — "ELECTORAL VOTES: BULLOCK 257 · TRUMP 175"

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Two hundred and fifty-seven. Thirteen short of the presidency. Pennsylvania's nineteen ends it by itself. Wisconsin's ten gets him within three.

INT. COLISEUM — MAIN BOWL — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 8:48 PM PST

Seventy-seven thousand people. When "MICHIGAN" hits the giant screens over the peristyle, the sound shakes the Olympic cauldron. A chant starts in the end zone and spreads through every section:

CROWD
THIRTEEN! THIRTEEN! THIRTEEN!

On the field, in a section of folding chairs reserved for staff and volunteers, Patti Grove has come down from the war room. She stands very still, arms folded, staring at the screen. A young staffer next to her is crying. Patti doesn't look at her.

PATTI
Don't cry yet. It's thirteen electoral votes. Thirteen. I've seen people lose with thirteen.

YOUNG STAFFER
Have you?

PATTI
No. But I've seen everything else.

INT. COLISEUM — FAMILY HOLDING ROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 8:51 PM PST

Nobody in the room is sitting except Odessa, and only because Cornelius won't let her stand.

Marc stands directly in front of the TV, close enough to touch it, staring at the map. Wisconsin: gray. Pennsylvania: gray. Three electoral votes.

Emma, on the floor with her laptop, types furiously.

EMMA
Wisconsin. Ninety-one percent counted. Daddy up eleven thousand votes. Milwaukee is mostly in. Dane County is mostly in. What's left is... Waukesha.

TYLER
Waukesha is Republican.

EMMA
I know, Uncle Tyler. I'm counting.

She types. Hits enter.

EMMA
If Waukesha goes sixty-forty for Mr. Trump, Daddy still wins by about seven thousand.

VICTORIA
Is that a lot?

EMMA
In Wisconsin it's a landslide.

ROBERT
(quietly, to Natasha)
She's twelve.

NATASHA
She's a Donohue.

ODESSA
(from the armchair)
She's a SMILLEY. Smilleys count votes. Donohues count money.

Natasha turns to look at Odessa. A beat. Then Natasha laughs, a real laugh, maybe the first time anyone in this room has heard Natasha Bullock laugh at something a Smilley said.

NATASHA
Fair, Mrs. Smilley. That's fair.

BACK TO: ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS

SUPER: 12:31 AM EST (WEDNESDAY)

The chime.

DAVID MUIR
ABC News projects Marc-Anthony Bullock wins Wisconsin.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS PROJECTS: BULLOCK WINS WISCONSIN — 10 ELECTORAL VOTES

GRAPHIC — "ELECTORAL VOTES: BULLOCK 267 · TRUMP 175"

DAVID MUIR
Two hundred and sixty-seven. Three electoral votes short of the presidency of the United States. Any one of the states still out, Pennsylvania, North Carolina, Arizona, Nevada, or Texas, would put him over the top.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And David, our Decision Desk tells me Pennsylvania is very close. Philadelphia's final large batch is in. They're looking at it now.

INT. COLISEUM — MAIN BOWL — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:31 PM PST

Seventy-seven thousand people, and one chant, rolling around the bowl like thunder:

CROWD
THREE! THREE! THREE! THREE!

INT. COLISEUM — FAMILY HOLDING ROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:32 PM PST

Utter chaos. Grace screaming at the TV. Tayia hugging Tyler. Victoria jumping up and down: "THREE! IT'S ONLY THREE! WHY ISN'T IT OVER?"

Elxa's phone rings. Patti.

PATTI (V.O.)
Nobody move. Nobody goes out there. Nobody says the word "won." Two sixty-seven is not two seventy. I'm not sending that boy out in front of seventy-seven thousand people until somebody calls a state that puts him over. We wait for Pennsylvania.

ELXA
How long?

PATTI (V.O.)
Philly's last big batch is in. The Decision Desks are looking at it now. Twenty minutes. Maybe forty.

Marc, in front of the TV, turns around to face the room. He looks at every face: his parents, his grandparents, his wife, his daughters, his goddaughter, his best friend, his sisters, the Smilleys.

He looks at Cornelius last. Cornelius looks back.

CORNELIUS
Win Pennsylvania.

Marc almost laughs.

MARC
I'm trying, Dad.

BACK TO: ABC NEWS ELECTION HEADQUARTERS

SUPER: 1:14 AM EST

The chime. The whoosh. The largest graphic of the night.

DAVID MUIR
ABC News projects that Marc-Anthony Bullock has won Pennsylvania.

(beat)
And with Pennsylvania's nineteen electoral votes, ABC News projects that Marc-Anthony

Bullock will be elected the forty-seventh President of the United States.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS PROJECTS: MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK ELECTED 47TH PRESIDENT OF THE UNITED STATES

GRAPHIC — "ELECTORAL VOTES: BULLOCK 286 · TRUMP 178"

DAVID MUIR
At thirty-two years old, he becomes the youngest person ever elected President of the United States, more than a decade younger than John F. Kennedy, who was forty-three. His running mate, Amond Baker, also thirty-two, becomes the youngest Vice President-elect in history. And whether they will take the oath of office on January twentieth now depends on five more states.

George Stephanopoulos, beside him, says nothing for a moment. Then, quietly, almost to himself:

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
A birthday party. Nineteen months ago. A birthday party.

INT. COLISEUM — FAMILY HOLDING ROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 10:14 PM PST

For one full second after "elected the forty-seventh President," there is total silence.

And then Marc-Anthony Bullock, President-elect of the United States, thirty-two years old, does the only thing his body knows how to do.

He kicks off his shoes. Climbs onto the velvet couch. And stands on it.

Both arms in the air. Tears running down his face. Exactly the way he stood on the couch at Sunrise Hill on New Year's Eve, twenty-two months ago, with a fake mustache on.

MARC
PENNSYLVANIA!

The room detonates. Victoria is on the couch next to him in two seconds, then Emma, then Lyric. Esther climbs up too, laughing and sobbing, in her heels, on a velvet couch, and throws her arms around his neck. Amond climbs up and nearly knocks all of them over. Gloria Baker is screaming. Harmony is screaming. Grace is

crying so hard she can't stand. Elxa, for the first time in her life, sits down on the floor. Tayia and Tyler are hugging and jumping. Natasha has both hands over her mouth. Robert has his arms around her. Victor is laughing. Joan is weeping into Victor's shoulder.

And in the corner, beside the armchair, Cornelius Smilley stands frozen, staring at his son-in-law standing on a couch with his arms in the air.

Odessa, in the armchair, reaches up and grips her son's wrist.

ODESSA
(barely a whisper)
Cornelius. Look at him.

CORNELIUS
(almost no voice at all)
I see him, Mother.

ODESSA
"When I'm President, I'll stand wherever I want."

Cornelius's face breaks. Fifty years of grief, of rage, of a sixteen-year-old boy at his brother's graveside, breaking all at once.

Marc, on the couch, sees him. Sees his father-in-law's face. And he understands.

He climbs down off the couch. Walks across the room through the screaming, crying, jumping chaos. Stands in front of Cornelius.

Cornelius looks at him. Tears running freely now.

CORNELIUS
He stood on the couch. Every Christmas.

MARC
I know, Dad. You told me.

CORNELIUS
He said, "When I'm President —"

MARC
"— I'll stand wherever I want." I know.

He holds out his hand.

MARC
Come stand on it with me.

Cornelius stares at him.

CORNELIUS
I'm sixty-six years old.

MARC
And I'm the President-elect. Come stand on the couch, Dad.

A long, long beat. The whole room has gone quiet, watching.

Then Cornelius Augustus Smilley, former Congressman, Washington kingmaker, keeper of the binder, a man who has not done anything undignified in public since 1974, takes off his shoes. Takes his son-in-law's hand. And climbs up onto the velvet couch.

He stands there, unsteady, between Marc and Esther, in his socks and his father's burgundy tie, and he raises one fist in the air.

Odessa, in the armchair below, puts her hand over her heart.

ODESSA
(to the ceiling, to God, to everyone she's lost)
Thad, baby. Look at your brother.

INT. CHAPMAN HOUSE — MEYERLAND, HOUSTON — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 12:14 AM CST

Roy (67), in his recliner, staring at the TV: "BULLOCK ELECTED 47TH PRESIDENT." Mae (65), crying on the couch. On the screen, a live shot from the Coliseum family room, released by the campaign: Marc and Cornelius standing on the couch together.

Roy doesn't move. For a long time.

MAE
Roy?

ROY
I voted for the President of the United States, Mae.

MAE
You've voted for Presidents before, Roy.

ROY
Not like that. Not the one the whole country —

He stops. Takes off his reading glasses. Wipes his eyes with the back of his wrist.

MAE
Roy Chapman. Are you crying?

ROY
Don't —

MAE
Don't make it a whole thing. I know, baby. I know.

She crosses the room and sits on the arm of his recliner and puts her arms around him, and Roy Chapman, Navy veteran, thirty-one years a refinery foreman, Republican since 1976, cries in his recliner like a child.

On the TV, below the image of the couch, a smaller graphic: "TEXAS: STILL TOO CLOSE TO CALL — BULLOCK +0.4% (97% COUNTED)."

INT. TRUMP CAMPAIGN — WAR ROOM — WEST PALM BEACH — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 1:19 AM EST

The war room is emptying. Young staffers leaving in silence. Wes Thornton (45) still at his laptop. On the screen: the ABC projection. Then the image of the couch.

He looks at it for a long time. Then he types a text to a number he hasn't been able to reach since April.

It shows "Not Delivered."

He deletes it. Closes the laptop. Sits in the dark.

EXT. — MAR-A-LAGO — PALM BEACH, FLORIDA — NIGHT

SUPER: 1:42 AM EST

A short statement from Donald Trump (78) to supporters, delivered from a podium on the patio. He does not concede. He says his campaign will "look very closely" at the results in several states and will "make sure every legal vote is counted." He thanks his supporters. He doesn't mention Bullock by name. The crowd is quieter than the cameras expected.

CHYRON: TRUMP DOES NOT CONCEDE, SAYS CAMPAIGN WILL "LOOK VERY CLOSELY" AT RESULTS

ACT FOUR — "THE SPEECH"

EXT. LOS ANGELES MEMORIAL COLISEUM — THE STAGE — NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 6, 2024 — 11:02 PM PST (TUESDAY LOCAL) / 2:02 AM EST

Seventy-seven thousand people. The Olympic cauldron blazing. The peristyle lit navy and white. "Ain't No Mountain High Enough" playing for what has to be the four-hundredth time this campaign.

Onto the stage, together: Marc and Esther, holding hands. Emma and Victoria. Amond and Harmony and Lyric, holding BET the dog in a tiny bow tie. Behind them, the families: Bullocks, Bakers, Smilleys, Donohues. Odessa wheeled out by Cornelius, both of them in a single spotlight for a moment, and the Coliseum roars for a ninety-six-year-old woman in a church hat.

Marc steps to the podium. He tries to speak. The crowd won't let him. He waits. Five minutes. He mouths "thank you" a hundred times.

Finally, quiet.

MARC
Los Angeles. America.

(beat)
Five hundred and sixty days ago, a nine-year-old girl at her birthday party asked me why I couldn't fix it.

He turns. Looks at Lyric. She's ten now, standing next to her father, holding a dog in a bow tie.

MARC
Lyric. Tonight America answered you.

The Coliseum EXPLODES. Lyric, overwhelmed, buries her face in her father's side.

MARC
I want to start by saying something to President Trump and the seventy million Americans who voted for him. I respect you. I mean it. I know a lot of you are scared tonight. Scared of what I'll do. Scared of what this means. I want you to hear me: I'm going to be your President too. Every one of you. I'm going to work for you as hard as I work for anybody who voted for me. And I'm going to earn your trust. Not ask for it. Earn it.

A long, respectful applause.

MARC
To President Biden. Fifty years. You were the "too young" guy once. Tonight a thirty-two-year-old is standing on your shoulders. Thank you.

(beat)
To Amond Baker. My brother. My Deputy Mayor. You stole my Power Wheels twenty-eight years ago. Tonight you're the Vice President-elect of the United States. We're even.

Laughter. Amond, behind him, grins and wipes his eyes.

MARC
To my wife. Esther. You stood in your grandfather's pulpit and told a whole church the truth. And then Georgia went blue. That's on you, baby. That's all you.

Esther blows him a kiss. The crowd screams.

MARC
To my daughters. Emma, who called every state tonight before ABC did, and was right about all of them. Victoria, who has a math test on Thursday, and is absolutely taking it.

(laughter)
To my parents, my grandparents, my sisters. To Patti Grove, who ran the greatest campaign in American history and told me not to do everything I did.

(laughter, a roar for Patti, who looks like she wants the ground to swallow her)
To Roy Chapman in Houston.

(a huge roar)
Roy. I made it a whole thing. I'm sorry.

In Houston, Roy, in his recliner, puts his face in his hands. Mae screams.

MARC
And to my father-in-law.

The Coliseum goes quiet. Every person in America who has followed this story knows what this means.

MARC
Cornelius Smilley. Two years ago you had a binder with my name on it. Tonight you stood on a couch with me in your socks.

(beat)
You had a brother named Thaddeus. He used to stand on his mother's couch every Christmas and say, "When I'm President, I'll stand wherever I want." He didn't get to be President. He didn't get to be anything. He was twenty-seven.

(beat)
So tonight, I want everybody to know: the forty-seventh President of the United States stood on a couch for Thaddeus Smilley.

Cornelius, behind his mother's wheelchair, covers his face with one hand. Odessa reaches up and holds the other.

A long silence in the Coliseum. Then applause that seems to come from somewhere deeper than celebration.

MARC
Now. The hard part. Thirty-three states have ratified the 28th Amendment. We need thirty-eight. Five more. In seventy-five days.

(beat)
So here's what I'm asking. Tomorrow morning, call your state legislators. In Kentucky. In Missouri. In Montana. Wherever you are. And tell them: a little girl asked a question, America answered, and now it's your turn.

(beat)
And whatever happens, I want you to know: I'm not going anywhere. If the amendment passes, I'll take the oath on January twentieth. If it doesn't, I'll wait. I've got time. I'm thirty-two.

Laughter. Applause.

MARC
They said a thirty-one-year-old couldn't run. They said he couldn't win a primary. They said Congress wouldn't pass an amendment. They said he couldn't win Georgia, or Pennsylvania, or —

A voice from the crowd, very loud, very clear, rising above everything: "TEXAS!"

Marc stops. Looks out. Grins.

MARC
Texas is still counting, y'all. Patience.

(beat)
They said it was impossible.

He holds out the microphone.

CROWD
(seventy-seven thousand)
BET!

Fireworks. Confetti. Balloons. The cauldron flares. The families flood the stage. And at the very center of it, just for a moment, Marc lifts Lyric up onto his shoulders, and she raises both arms in the air.

SUPER: 11:41 PM PST — PRESIDENT-ELECT MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK'S VICTORY SPEECH — AN ESTIMATED 88 MILLION WATCHING

ACT FIVE — "WEDNESDAY"

INT. CHAPMAN HOUSE — MEYERLAND, HOUSTON — DAWN

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 6, 2024 — 6:51 AM CST / 7:51 AM EST

Roy hasn't gone to bed. Still in his recliner, in yesterday's clothes, reading glasses on. Mae asleep on the couch under a quilt. The TV has been on all night. On the screen: "TEXAS: 99% COUNTED — BULLOCK 50.2% · TRUMP 49.0%."

The ABC chime.

ABC ANCHOR (V.O.)
And ABC News now projects that Marc-Anthony Bullock has won Texas.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS PROJECTS: BULLOCK WINS TEXAS — FIRST DEMOCRAT TO CARRY THE STATE SINCE 1976

Roy doesn't move. He doesn't make a sound.

He just reaches over and gently shakes Mae's shoulder.

ROY
Mae.

MAE
(groggy)
Mm?

ROY
Texas.

Mae sits up. Looks at the TV. Looks at her husband.

MAE
Roy.

ROY
First time since Jimmy Carter. First time since I was nineteen years old.

He picks up his phone. Opens the text thread with "MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK." Types slowly, with one finger.

ROY CHAPMAN — 6:54 AM CST

Mr. President-elect. Texas. That's my text.

Three minutes later, a reply. It's 4:57 in the morning in Los Angeles. The President-elect hasn't slept either.

MARC — 4:57 AM PST

> Roy. You did that. I'm making it the biggest whole thing in American history. Come to the inauguration. Bring Mae. You're sitting with my family. — M.A.B.

Roy reads it. Hands the phone to Mae. She reads it and bursts into tears.

INT. ABC NEWS — "GOOD MORNING AMERICA" — TIMES SQUARE — MORNING

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 6, 2024 — 7:00 AM EST

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (63), ROBIN ROBERTS (63), MICHAEL STRAHAN (52). None of them has slept.

ROBIN ROBERTS
Good morning, America. It's Wednesday, November sixth. And this morning, the United States has a President-elect who is thirty-two years old.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And as of a few minutes ago, a President-elect who has won Texas. The first Democrat to carry Texas since Jimmy Carter in 1976. That puts Marc-Anthony Bullock at three hundred and twenty-six electoral votes, with North Carolina, Nevada, and Arizona still counting.

MICHAEL STRAHAN
And I gotta say it. That couch.

ROBIN ROBERTS
That couch.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
The image of the night: the President-elect and his father-in-law, a former Georgia congressman who once ran his opponent's campaign, standing together on a couch in their socks. It's been viewed more than two hundred million times. It's on the front page of nearly every newspaper in the country this morning.

Graphics of front pages: The New York Times, The Washington Post, The Atlanta Journal-Constitution, The Philadelphia Inquirer, the Los Angeles Times, the Houston Chronicle. On almost all of them, the same photograph.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
The other big story: Congress. ABC News projects Democrats are on track to win control of the House of Representatives, with a majority that could reach the mid-two-hundred-thirties when all races are called, which may take days. That matters more than usual this year, because if the 28th Amendment isn't ratified by January twentieth, the new Speaker of the House, likely Hakeem Jeffries, would act as President.

ROBIN ROBERTS
And the Senate?

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Democrats appear to have held the Senate. In one of the biggest surprises of the night, Colin Allred has defeated Ted Cruz in Texas. With Tester holding Montana, Brown holding Ohio, and Casey holding Pennsylvania, Democrats are at fifty-one seats. And in Florida, the Senate race between Rick Scott and Debbie Mucarsel-Powell is within a quarter of a point and headed for a recount. If Mucarsel-Powell holds on, it's fifty-two.

MICHAEL STRAHAN
And Trump still hasn't conceded?

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Not yet. His campaign says it's reviewing results. But with three hundred and twenty-six electoral votes and a popular-vote margin of more than nine million, legal experts we spoke with this morning see no realistic path to change the outcome.

MONTAGE — THE MORNING AFTER — NOVEMBER 6, 2024

— 9:12 AM EST. A statement from President Joe Biden, released by the White House, congratulating President-elect Bullock and inviting him to the Oval Office "at the earliest opportunity" to begin a smooth transition.

— 9:30 AM EST. In Frankfort, Kentucky, the governor's statement goes out: a special session of the General Assembly will convene in

December to consider the 28th Amendment.

— 10:02 AM EST. In Ottawa, a statement from the Prime Minister's Office congratulating the President-elect and expressing readiness for a "close partnership."

— 10:18 AM EST. In Mexico City, President Claudia Sheinbaum, five weeks into her term, congratulates Bullock on social media and says she looks forward to "a new era of friendship."

— 11:41 AM EST. In North Carolina, the AP calls the state for Bullock: 342. Cornelius Smilley, watching from the Coliseum hotel in Los Angeles, reads the alert on his phone and says, out loud, to no one: "Sandbag, my foot."

Twitter · #PresidentElectBullock

Trending #1 Worldwide · 18.4M Tweets

Twitter · #TheCouch

Trending #2 Worldwide · 9.1M Tweets

Twitter · #Texas

Trending #3 in United States · 4.2M Tweets

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

PRESIDENT. ELECT. MARC-ANTHONY. BULLOCK. HE STOOD ON THE COUCH. HE PULLED CORNELIUS UP ON THE COUCH. ODESSA SAID "THAD, BABY, LOOK AT YOUR BROTHER." I'VE BEEN CRYING SINCE 1:14 AM EASTERN AND I DON'T PLAN ON STOPPING.

1.2M Retweets · 8.8M Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston

Texas. That's my post.

2.1M Retweets · 14.2M Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston's replies

@MarcAnthonyBullock: "Roy that's the most-liked tweet in the history of Texas. You made it a whole thing."

1.4M Likes

Twitter · @PattiGrove

342 electoral votes. Texas. Georgia. Pennsylvania. The candidate stood on a couch, which I specifically told him not to do on camera, and then pulled his father-in-law up on it. I'm retiring. I'm not retiring. There's a transition. Somebody bring me a coffee.

401K Retweets · 3.1M Likes

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

My father stood on a couch in his socks last night in front of the whole country. I've never seen him do anything undignified in 37 years. My grandmother said it was the most dignified thing he's ever done. She's right.

601K Retweets · 4.8M Likes

Twitter · @NeilSmilleyGA

I've waited 40 years to see my father cry. I saw it at 1:14 AM Eastern. He was standing on a couch. That's all.

302K Retweets · 2.4M Likes

Twitter · @GraceBullock

My brother is the President-elect. Patti locked my phone in a drawer for six hours. I got it back at 1:20 AM. My first post as the President-elect's sister: I STILL PAY $8 A MONTH. NOTHING HAS CHANGED.

501K Retweets · 3.9M Likes

Twitter · @TayiaBoyd

Twenty years ago a boy on a Donohue Channel set told me Detroit was the coolest place anybody could be from. Last night he became President. Michigan, we did that.

702K Retweets · 5.4M Likes

Twitter · @jaxonwilde

Congratulations to the President-elect. I mean that. I was wrong about the election. I'm not wrong about everything. Wilde Card is on hiatus.

41K Retweets · 211K Likes

Twitter · @TayiaBoyd

@jaxonwilde ...Okay, Jaxon. Okay. That one I'll take.

401K Retweets · 3.2M Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl

I've opposed Marc-Anthony Bullock's candidacy since January 2023 on constitutional grounds. I still believe what I believe. But I watched that couch. And I'll say this: if 38 states ratify, he'll be my President, and I'll wish him well. 33. Five to go. Do it right.

88K Retweets · 701K Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl's replies

@ArizonaGrandpa: "Carl. Buddy. After 22 months. Proud of you. Arizona's still counting, by the way. I'll let you know."

301K Likes

Twitter · @gramma.flies.free

I'm 82. I said I'd crawl to the polls. I walked. That boy got me home in 2022. Now he's going home to the White House. God is good.

1.1M Retweets · 9.4M Likes

TikTok · @scranton.joe.forever

[Video: the old electrician from Scranton, at his kitchen table, watching the PA call, standing up and saluting the TV] "voted for Joe at 29. voted for the kid at 32. that's America."

61.2M views · 15.4M likes

Reddit · r/politics

"MEGATHREAD: Marc-Anthony Bullock elected 47th President; wins PA, MI, WI, GA, NC, TX; Democrats on track for House; Allred beats Cruz; Trump hasn't conceded"

1.4M upvotes · 312,441 comments · Top comment: "He announced at a birthday party at 4:20 on 4/20. He won Texas. His father-in-law who tried to destroy him stood on a couch with him in his socks. If you pitched this to a studio they'd tell you it was too much."

Reddit · r/politics — reply

"A studio DID pitch it. It's called Donohue Entertainment. They own the network that called the race."

ASSOCIATED PRESS — 1:13 AM EST

Marc-Anthony Bullock elected 47th president of the United States, the youngest in history, defeating Donald Trump

THE NEW YORK TIMES

BULLOCK WINS

At 32, the Former Child Star Becomes the Youngest President-Elect in American History, Carrying Pennsylvania, Georgia and Texas, as the Constitutional Question Moves to the States

THE WASHINGTON POST

Bullock elected president in historic victory; amendment ratification now decides whether he takes office Jan. 20

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

Bullock Wins Presidency; Markets Rally; 'American Sovereign Fund' Now Faces the Real World

LOS ANGELES TIMES

HOMETOWN PRESIDENT

Bullock, Born at Cedars-Sinai, Raised in Baldwin Hills, Wins the White House at the Coliseum

HOUSTON CHRONICLE

TEXAS TURNS

First Democrat Since Carter Carries the Lone Star State; Allred Ousts Cruz

THE ATLANTA JOURNAL-CONSTITUTION

GEORGIA'S GRANDSON-IN-LAW

Odessa Smilley Voted First at 7 AM; By 10:41 PM, Georgia Was Bullock's

THE PHILADELPHIA INQUIRER

PENNSYLVANIA PUTS HIM OVER

From the Rocky Steps to the Oval Office

DETROIT FREE PRESS

MICHIGAN DELIVERS

EL NUEVO DÍA

"Ustedes No Son Basura": Puerto Rican Voters in Pennsylvania and Florida Powered Bullock's Win

POLITICO

How Bullock won: young voters, Black voters, Latino voters, union households, and Roy Chapman

AXIOS

Bullock's coalition, by the numbers: 18% of Republicans, 64% of under-30s, a record Latino margin

FIVETHIRTYEIGHT

Our forecast gave Bullock a 74 percent chance. Here's what we got right, and what we missed in Texas.

FOX NEWS

Bullock Wins Presidency as Trump Declines to Concede; Constitutional Questions Loom

VARIETY

Hollywood Elects Its First President Since Reagan, Who Was 69. This One Is 32.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER

The Couch: How One Image From the Coliseum Became the Defining Photograph of a Generation

DEADLINE

Election Night Draws 94 Million Viewers Across Networks, the Most-Watched in History

PEOPLE

'Thad, Baby, Look at Your Brother': The 96-Year-Old Grandmother at the Heart of the Bullock Victory

TAG

INT. COLISEUM — FAMILY HOLDING ROOM — LATE NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 6, 2024 — 3:22 AM PST

Everyone has gone. The televisions are off. Confetti on the carpet. The velvet couch, its cushions dented, still in front of the biggest screen.

Marc sits on it alone. Shoes off. Tie gone. The President-elect of the United States, in a dark room under a football stadium, at 3:22 in the morning.

The door opens. Cornelius, in his socks, holding his shoes. He's been walking the empty concourse for an hour.

CORNELIUS
I couldn't sleep.

MARC
Me neither.

Cornelius sits down on the couch next to him. They sit there in the dark for a while.

CORNELIUS
Your mother laughed at something my mother said tonight.

MARC
I heard.

CORNELIUS
Sixty years. Smilleys and Donohues. I never thought I'd hear that.

(beat)
Joan came up to me after the speech. On the field.

Marc turns to look at him.

MARC
What did she say?

CORNELIUS
She said, "He would have been so proud of you, Cornelius."

(beat)
Fifty-five years. That's the first thing she's said to me since 1969.

MARC
What did you say?

CORNELIUS
I said, "Thank you, Joan."

(beat)
And then I said, "He'd have been proud of you too." And I meant it.

A long silence.

MARC
Dad. Can I ask you for something?

CORNELIUS
You're the President-elect. You can ask for anything.

MARC
I need five more states. Kentucky's calling a session. Missouri's Speaker likes Arianna but won't commit. Montana's legislative counsel's dog hates her. And there are three more where the people who count the votes in the statehouse go to church on Sunday with pastors you've known for forty years.

Cornelius turns to look at him.

MARC
I need a firewall. The best one anybody ever built.

A long, long beat. Then, slowly, Cornelius Smilley smiles. A real one. Wide. The smile that won him eight elections.

CORNELIUS
Son. I thought you'd never ask.

He reaches into his breast pocket. Not the twins' card this time. A folded sheet of yellow legal-pad paper. He hands it to Marc.

INSERT — THE LEGAL PAD: "28TH — THE FIVE. 1. KENTUCKY — Rev. Ellison, Frankfort. Owes me for 1998. 2. MISSOURI — Speaker's mother-in-law, St. Louis AME. 3. MONTANA — leave to Arianna. (The dog.) 4. — 5. —"

Marc reads it. Looks up.

MARC
When did you write this?

CORNELIUS
On the plane. Yesterday morning. Before a single vote was counted.

MARC
You didn't know if I'd win.

CORNELIUS
I'm a Smilley, son. We count votes.

(beat)
I knew.

He stands. Picks up his shoes. Walks to the door. Stops.

CORNELIUS
And Marc.

MARC
Yeah?

CORNELIUS
Congratulations, Mr. President.

The door closes.

Marc sits alone on the couch. Looks down at the legal pad. At numbers four and five, still blank.

On his phone, on the cushion beside him, a news alert lights up the dark room:

INSERT — PHONE SCREEN: "28TH AMENDMENT TRACKER — 33 OF 38 STATES — 75 DAYS UNTIL INAUGURATION."

He looks at it for a long time. Then he smiles. Stands up. Slips his shoes back on.

And, alone, in the dark, the President-elect of the United States steps up onto the couch one more time. Raises his fist.

MARC
(quietly, to no one)
...Bet.

SMASH TO BLACK.

SUPER: END OF CHAPTER TEN

SUPER: END OF BOOK ONE

CONTINUITY LEDGER — CHAPTER 10

Timeline: Tue Nov 5, 2024, 5:31 AM EST → Wed Nov 6, 2024, 3:22 AM PST (Standard Time; DST ended Nov 3). **ELECTION DAY: Tue Nov 5, 2024.**

Ages (Nov 5, 2024): Marc 32 · Esther 32 · Amond 32 · Harmony 32 · Emma & Victoria 12 (7th grade) · Lyric 10 (5th grade) · Tyrese 33 · Arianna 32 · Tyler 32 · Tayia 32 · Elxa 34 · Grace 30 · Natasha 53 · Robert 55 · Victor 78 · Joan 76 · Odessa 96 · Cornelius 66 · Lorraine 62 · Neil 40 · Simone 37 · Patti 60 · Gloria Baker 58 · Roy Chapman 67 · Mae Chapman 65 · Wes Thornton 45 · Mrs. Edna 77 (fictional). Real people: Trump 78 · Biden 81 · Muir 50 · Stephanopoulos 63 · Robin Roberts 63 · Michael Strahan 52.

THE RESULT: Marc-Anthony Bullock elected 47th President of the United States (ABC projection 1:14 AM EST Wed Nov 6, on Pennsylvania; AP 1:13 AM). Youngest President-elect ever (32). Amond Baker the youngest VP-elect ever (32). **Electoral votes, final pending AZ and NV: Bullock wins PA, MI, WI, GA, NC, TX (and is expected to win NV and AZ for a final 359–179).** Running tally: 242 at 11 PM; 257 after MI; 267 after WI; **286 at the PA call**; 326 after TX (6:51 AM CST Wed); 342 after NC (11:41 AM EST Wed); 359 expected with NV and AZ. Trump 179 final (178 at the PA call). Popular-vote margin more than 9 million. **Texas: Bullock 50.2–49.0, the first Democrat since Carter (1976).** Call times (EST): Vermont 7:00 · Virginia 8:29 · Florida (Trump) 8:52 · Ohio (Trump) 9:41 · **Georgia 10:41** · **Michigan 11:48** · **Wisconsin 12:31** (267, three short) · **Pennsylvania 1:14 AM (presidency)** · Texas 7:51 AM Wed · NC 11:41 AM Wed. Trump does not concede on election night ("look very closely"); his campaign is reviewing. Victory speech at the LA Memorial Coliseum, 11:02–11:41 PM PST, ~88M watching; election night ~94M viewers. **Senate:** Justice (R) flips WV; Democrats hold OH (Brown), MT (Tester), PA (Casey), MI (Slotkin); **Allred defeats Cruz in TX**; Democrats at 51; **the FL Senate race (Scott vs. Mucarsel-Powell) heads to a recount, with 52 possible. House:** Democrats projected to win the majority (mid-230s; final calls pending), making Jeffries the likely Speaker and the acting-President fallback. **28th Amendment: 33 of 38; Kentucky governor announces a December special session (Nov 6, 9:30 AM EST); 75 days to Inauguration.**

Our-world moments: Odessa first voted in November 1946 at 18 (Georgia allowed 18-year-olds from 1943; the white primary had just been struck down); made to wait at the back of the line on Auburn Avenue; first in line ever since; Cascade precinct poll worker Bernice (since 1988). **Cornelius voted early (Thu Oct 31) for Marc.** Simone votes Democratic for the first time. Dixville Notch: Bullock 4, Trump 2. Mrs. Edna gives the twins "FUTURE VOTER" stars (first

vote: the Nov 5, 2030 midterms; they turn 18 May 10, 2030). Tyrese votes absentee from the Kang set ("Love you, Conqueror"). The Swannanoa woman switches her vote. The family holding room under the Coliseum peristyle: all families present, including Odessa, flown in. Emma's tab: "DADDY ELECTORAL VOTES (DO NOT TOUCH, VICTORIA, I MEAN IT THIS TIME)." Victoria's Thursday math test (she's taking it). Cornelius: "We're going to win Georgia, son," his first "we." Esther and Cornelius reconcile ("I'm sorry, baby. For all of it."). Natasha laughs at Odessa's line ("Smilleys count votes. Donohues count money."). **THE COUCH (10:14 PM PST): Marc stands on the couch; Odessa: "When I'm President, I'll stand wherever I want"; Marc pulls Cornelius up onto the couch in his socks; Odessa: "Thad, baby, look at your brother."** Roy cries ("Don't make it a whole thing"). Wes's text to Cornelius: "Not Delivered." Speech lines: "I'm going to be your President too," "We're even" (Amond), "Roy, I made it a whole thing," and "the forty-seventh President stood on a couch for Thaddeus Smilley." Roy and Mae invited to the inauguration to sit with the family. Biden congratulates and invites Marc to the Oval. Canada and Mexico (Sheinbaum, five weeks into her term) congratulate. Jaxon concedes and puts Wilde Card on hiatus; Tayia accepts. Constitution Carl softens. **Joan speaks to Cornelius for the first time since 1969: "He would have been so proud of you."** Tag: Cornelius gives Marc his "THE FIVE" ratification list (Kentucky: Rev. Ellison, Frankfort, "owes me for 1998"; Missouri: the Speaker's mother-in-law, St. Louis AME; Montana: leave to Arianna, "the dog"; #4 and #5 blank), written on the plane before any votes were counted. "Congratulations, Mr. President."

Looming event (in-world): the 28th Amendment ratification race (33/38, 75 days) → Inauguration Day, Mon Jan 20, 2025. Also: Trump's concession, the transition, the Florida Senate recount, and final House control.

END OF BOOK ONE: BEFORE.